The Princeton University campus is a knowledge seeker's dream. On the verdant acres, buildings in chiselled grey stones appeared to emerge from the depths of earth, bringing with it buried secrets of yore; their spires seeking greater heights of the azure sky. Towers stood like sentinels of scholarship.

Students and professors—indistinguishable at times—streamed in and out of the imposing buildings that housed libraries, laboratories and dormitories showing virtually no signs of the great ideas they fostered to make the world a better place. During spring and summer, some studied under the trees, on the grass; some others exchanged banter, with salads that came free from the dining room and hamburgers for which they paid.

The campus allowed students who were not just bright, but with a never-ending quest for knowledge. Professors were demanding to the extent that if anyone mediocre happened to turn up there for research, he would live the rest of his life as a frustrated student. Geniuses were tolerated, toilers were appreciated. It was also one of the few universities of the Ivy League that NASA gave sensitive contracts to.

For courses like mine—Master of Engineering Sciences in the Aerospace and Mechanical Sciences—classes happened seven to nine in the morning. Later, one was free to do projects in labs round the clock—you only need to have a technician who would not crib for being forced to put in long hours. The department was spread over 22,000 acres, which included an airstrip and an aircraft.

The first challenge was to register under septuagenarian Professor Lugi Crocco. Considered an outstanding professor, Crocco had stopped taking new students. In fact, he had stopped coming to the campus; the university was happy to have him agree to be on the rolls and guide students from his home.

Those who thought the professor to be prude didn't know the real reason: his wife was bedridden, and he would not move away from her bedside. Prof. Crocco changed my perception of Americans who, I thought till then, lacked the family values we Indians were so proud of.